

This essay is a structured adaptation of arguments originally presented in a Facebook post by the user "TK" (sometime before 2020). The post circulated informally and is no longer available online. A later thread preserving and discussing these arguments was published by FrontierIndica and can be accessed here: <https://x.com/frontierindica/status/1411901659526025218>.

Civilizational Realism and the Failure of Hindu Civic Nationalism

The Hindu right in India is captive to a flawed and naive understanding of human nature. That understanding is not indigenous to the tradition it claims to defend. It is rooted in Enlightenment liberalism, inherited uncritically through the ideological legacy of Savarkar, and compounded by each successive generation of the Hindutva movement into a set of operational assumptions that contradict observable reality at every point they are tested.

The Savarkarite Foundation and Its European Sources

In *Essentials of Hindutva*, Savarkar explicitly endorsed what is now called the Aryan Migration Hypothesis while arguing that through intermarriages, allegiance to the fatherland, and cultural assimilation, the diverse peoples of the subcontinent could be molded into a single race bonded by common blood and culture. His definition of Hindu was correspondingly sweeping: anyone residing in or descending from the Indian subcontinent and following any belief or non-belief system originating from the region qualified, which excluded Abrahamic faiths as a category while accommodating individual Muslims, Christians, and sects such as the Ismaili Bohras within the Hindu fold provided they pledged the relevant allegiance. The model was explicitly Zionist in its self-understanding, Hindutva functioning for Hindus as Zionism functions for Jews, a civilizational identity capable of unifying a diverse people into a coherent force defending their holy land, their people, and their culture against the Abrahamic threats posed primarily by Christianity and Islam.

The intellectual genealogy of this framework is not obscure. Savarkar's prison walls in the Andamans were lined with cutouts from John Stuart Mill and Herbert Spencer. Mill's blank slate view holds that the human mind at birth is a *tabula rasa*, infinitely malleable through environment and social policy. That assumption seeps directly into Savarkar's belief that cultural assimilation and interbreeding alone can forge a unified people. Spencer's social evolutionism provided the complementary framework for thinking about civilizational development as a progressive movement toward greater integration and coherence.

The difficulty is that these assumptions ignore the most stable findings of evolutionary psychology, behavioural genetics, and the historical sociology of group competition. Human instincts concerning tribe, ancestry, and religion are not recent cultural constructions that can be dissolved by civic pledges or intermarriage schemes. They are deep behavioural dispositions with long evolutionary histories, far more potent as

motivators of collective action than any allegiance to shared geography. The civic nationalist framework Savarkar absorbed from Mill treats these dispositions as epiphenomena that rational institutions can overcome. They are not epiphenomena. They form the substrate upon which all institution-building occurs and against which civic constructions must continuously struggle if they are to survive.

The Two Principal Errors

Savarkar's framework commits two principal errors that ramify through everything the Hindutva movement has built upon his foundation.

The first error is the assumption that unity can be manufactured through social policy alone, through interbreeding, shared rituals, and symbolic pledges of allegiance, without accounting for the enduring biological, psychological, and power structures that govern how groups actually relate to one another. Power dynamics do not dissolve because groups intermarry. In many cases interbreeding intensifies competition for dominance within the newly mixed hierarchy, because the mixed group's internal stratification becomes a new arena for the conflicts that intermarriage was supposed to resolve. The history of multi-ethnic civic nationalist projects across the modern period illustrates this dynamic repeatedly. Savarkar had access to this historical material, but the Millian framework prevented him from reading it accurately.

The second error lies in the disregard for the distinct sects, traditions, and religious systems within what Savarkar called the Hindu civilizational complex. Shared religion and shared practice are not supplementary to civic allegiance. They are the mechanisms through which group cohesion actually operates across generations. People are motivated to defend their tribe through shared ancestry, shared territory, and shared religion and traditions, and the last of these is not a minor consideration that an abstract geographic pledge can substitute for. A definition of Hindu identity expansive enough to include groups that do not share the ritual, metaphysical, or ethical commitments that constitute Hindu civilization does not represent an expansive definition. It represents an empty one. A boundary that includes everything protects nothing.

The Post-Savarkar Degeneration and the OIT Calculation

The generation that followed Savarkar retained his premises while stripping away much of the intellectual coherence that had existed in his formulation. Savarkar believed that Hindu unity would have to be created through deliberate civilizational work, through the assimilative project he was consciously designing. The contemporary Hindutva movement has assumed that such unity already exists. It does not. The presumption converts a difficult and ongoing political project into a fantasy whose maintenance requires continuous falsification of observable evidence.

The most visible expression of this falsification is the Hindutva movement's embrace of the Out of India Theory, not out of any serious engagement with the historiographical, archaeological, or population genetic evidence, but out of perceived political utility. The calculation is straightforward and has been made explicit enough times that it requires

no inference: the AMT allegedly provides ideological ammunition for the narrative that upper caste Aryans arrived from outside, destroyed the Indus Valley Civilization, and subjugated the native Dalit and tribal populations, thereby providing ideological ammunition to Ambedkarite and Christian conversion movements. If Dalits and tribals could be persuaded that no such migration occurred, the calculation runs, their historical grievances would dissolve and they would join the Hindu unity project against Islam and the West.

The calculation fails even on its own terms. The ancient DNA evidence demonstrating substantial steppe ancestry in upper-caste North Indian populations is not going to disappear because the Hindutva movement wishes it would. The evidence continues to accumulate with each newly sequenced ancient genome from South Asian archaeological sites. A political strategy that depends on suppressing an empirical finding that grows stronger with every year of research is a strategy that will eventually be destroyed by the evidence it tries to ignore, at the worst possible moment and by the worst possible combination of adversaries.

Underlying the OIT embrace is the same blank slate assumption that shaped Savarkar's original framework, now operating at a more extreme register. Savarkar at least believed that Hindu unity would need to be created through sustained civilizational work. The contemporary Hindutva movement has taken the blank slate logic a step further and assumed that the unity already exists, that the genetic and civilizational distinctions produced by at minimum two millennia of rigid caste endogamy are not meaningful or significant, and that the OIT narrative's acceptance would be sufficient to activate a latent solidarity currently suppressed only by false historical consciousness. Despite more than two millennia of documented rigid caste endogamy, and despite population genetic evidence showing that Indian jati groups exhibit levels of endogamy among the highest in the world, the Hindu right continues to claim that no meaningful genetic or civilizational distinctions exist between castes, that Hindus already form one people whose apparent differences are superficial and politically constructed. At least Savarkar believed that Hindus could become a single race through intermarriage. This lot has taken it a step further and assumed that they already are. This is a more radical blank slatism than Savarkar's, and it is less defensible rather than more.

The Hindu Unity Machine and Its Costs

The practical consequences of governing under these assumptions are visible and consistent. The project of Hindu unity has required and continues to require constant concessions to SC, ST, and OBC constituencies: incentives for inter-caste marriages presented as instruments of civilizational integration, demographic control schemes that in practice target upper caste fertility as visible in Assam, and historical fabrications whose brazenness is proportionate to the political desperation driving them. Yogi Adityanath's claim that Hanuman and Valmiki were Dalits is the most concentrated available example, but it represents the logical terminus of a strategy that treats historical truth as negotiable collateral in the pursuit of electoral arithmetic. The political imperative is transparent: secure votes from Dalit communities by conceding both historical narrative and civilizational prestige, absorbing the reputational cost of the fabrication on the assumption that the electoral gain justifies it.

The delusional thinking is most concentrated among the upper caste and predominantly Brahmin intelligentsia within the Hindu right. This formation constitutes approximately three percent of the Indian population and has convinced itself that it is part of an undifferentiated eighty percent Hindu mass, without serious attention to the intra-Hindu fault lines that make this self-conception a fantasy. The Hindu right does not typically address the Dalit problem seriously for two reasons that are rarely stated plainly. First, it fears losing the imaginary Hindu unity with its supposedly based and redpilled Dalit comrades, declining to see them as the thoroughgoing opportunists many of them are. Second, it does not regard intra-Hindu conflict as a problem worth serious analytical attention because in its framework it is a fight between two groups of Hindus, a minor skirmish within the larger project of addressing threats posed by Christianity and Islam to Hindu civilization. The Dalit hostility this formation dismisses is not minor, and the Dalit political actors it treats as natural allies are in many cases operating with interests that are at best instrumental and at worst directly adversarial to the Hindu civilizational project.

The Elastic Definition and the Trojan Horse Problem

The incoherence of the Hindutva definition of Hindu deepens as the category expands. The current operational definition indiscriminately includes Buddhists, Sikhs, tribal communities, and certain sects within Islam and Christianity provided they symbolically align with what is called the fatherland. The alignment remains symbolic precisely because it requires no substantive commitment to the ritual, metaphysical, or ethical framework that constitutes Hindu civilization in any serious sense. The question of whether the vast majority of people in these groups even identify as Hindu is not an abstract theological dispute but a direct operational question for any political project that depends on their participation.

A definition capacious enough to include groups that actively contest the tradition's foundational claims does not create a larger tent. It produces a tent without walls into which any formation can walk and occupy space without accepting the obligations that membership originally required. When RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat has on several occasions extended the Hindu category toward Muslims and Christians as well, the project's definitional incoherence has reached its logical terminus. They might as well start calling Muslims and Christians Hindus and bury their heads in the sand and pretend they have addressed civilizational threats. In some respects, that is precisely what has happened.

Who Is the Useful Idiot

By refusing to confront the reality of inter-group conflict within the Hindu fold, and by insisting that history can be rewritten to conceal caste antagonisms that have two millennia of material and genetic evidence behind them, the Hindu right performs the function of the useful idiot in the precise sense: continuously ceding power, prestige, and narrative control to formations that view it with suspicion or contempt while pursuing a unity that the concessions themselves demonstrate does not exist.

The Hindutva OIT position and the Ambedkarite AMT position mirror one another in a deeper sense than either side acknowledges. Both treat population genetic and archaeological evidence as raw material for political instrumentalization rather than as the empirical foundation that political strategy must accommodate. The Ambedkarite activist uses the migration evidence to construct a grievance narrative. The Hindutva ideologue denies the migration evidence to neutralize that narrative. Neither engages honestly with what the evidence actually shows or what an honest acknowledgment of it would require of political strategy.

The question of who is playing the game and who is the useful idiot in this arrangement does not require a genius to answer. A project that purchases electoral coalition maintenance by ceding historical narrative, social prestige, institutional space, and demographic advantage to formations that did not earn it and will not reciprocate it is not advancing Hindu civilizational interests. The Hindu right's characteristic response to this observation is to double down on the unity narrative rather than engage with its falsification by lived political reality, which is itself a demonstration of how thoroughly the blank slate assumption has disabled the formation's capacity for honest assessment.

The Limits of Hindu Civic Nationalism

The difficulty is not merely tactical. It is conceptual. A political movement built on the assumption that human groups are infinitely malleable, that historical antagonisms can be dissolved through symbolic gestures of unity, and that deep civilizational distinctions can be ignored in the interest of electoral arithmetic will repeatedly misread the environment in which it operates.

Civic nationalism built on blank slate assumptions is a dead end. The path forward cannot be found in the Hindu unity machine's electoral arithmetic, which purchases votes by ceding civilizational ground, nor in the mirror fantasy of constructing a common Indo-European racial identity with those whose actual political interests and formation bear no relationship to Hindu civilization. The latter substitutes genetic ancestry mythology for genuine institutional and philosophical work and is no less a form of larping than the unity machine's pretense that all eighty percent are one people.

A political framework built on premises that contradict observable reality cannot indefinitely avoid the consequences of that contradiction. The Hindu civic nationalist project rests precisely on such premises. Until those premises are confronted directly, the movement will continue to misdiagnose both its allies and its adversaries, continue to make the concessions that the misdiagnosis requires, and continue to mistake the resulting electoral outcomes for civilizational progress. The strategic failures that follow from that misdiagnosis will persist for exactly as long as the movement finds it more comfortable to maintain the fantasy than to reckon with what a serious civilizational politics would actually demand of it.